MPI LANCHESTER–OSIPOV

Assessment of the military power of eight states

United States, Russia, France, United Kingdom, Germany, Israel, Ukraine, Iran — a rapid assessment under the Lanchester–Osipov MPI methodology

Document 2 of 5 · Country assessment

Data cut-off: October 2026 · Open sources
Military power assessment programme for states · project documentation

Contents

Summary.....
1. How the assessment was obtained.....
2. Comparison.....
  2.1. Key data.....
  2.2. Sensitivity to weights.....
  2.3. Power projection.....
  2.4. Pairwise MPI ratios.....
  2.5. Nuclear axis.....
3. United States.....
4. Russia.....
5. France.....
6. United Kingdom.....
7. Germany.....
8. Israel.....
9. Ukraine.....
10. Iran.....
11. Limitations of the assessment.....
Sources.....

If page numbers are not visible, press F9 in Word (update field) or right-click the table of contents → “Update field”.

Summary

Rank	Country	MPI	90% interval	Rank in 90% of runs	With nuclear as a pillar	Without alliances	Nuclear status	λ, thousand km
1	United States	90.4	87.5–92.3	1	90.8	90.6	nuclear triad	12.0
2	France	66.9	63.4–70.0	2–4	67.5	65.4	Nuclear, 2-leg	7.0
3	Israel	64.4	59.6–68.5	2–5	64.0	63.7	Nuclear, limited	4.0
4	Russia	63.4	57.7–68.3	2–6	65.9	65.3	nuclear triad	5.0
5	United Kingdom	62.0	58.4–65.3	3–6	62.3	60.2	Nuclear, 2-leg	7.0
6	Germany	58.9	55.3–62.2	4–6	54.3	56.9	No nuclear	4.0
7	Ukraine	47.3	39.2–53.0	7	44.1	46.8	No nuclear	2.5
8	Iran	31.5	22.4–38.1	8	31.3	32.4	Threshold	3.0

MPI — the index excluding strategic forces (the nuclear axis is separate), CES aggregation ρ = 0.5, “balanced” weights. Intervals — Monte Carlo, 4,000 runs: pillar scores ± country σ, weights ±15%, ρ from 0.3 to 0.7.

Main conclusions

1. **The United States is the only leader with a clear gap** (MPI ≈ 90, rank stable in 100% of runs). The gap is created by multipliers: space, intelligence, AEW&C, tankers, global logistics and the economy.
2. **Ranks 2 to 6 are statistically indistinguishable.** France, Israel, Russia, the United Kingdom and Germany fall within the range 59–67 with overlapping intervals. The order within the group is set by the weights: with “conventional” weights (close to GFP) and weights for the land theatre in Europe, Russia moves into 2nd place; with “expeditionary” weights — France and the United Kingdom.
3. **The profiles differ more than the final scores.** Russia has the largest ground forces, nuclear arsenal and depth, but the economy, alliances and C4ISR pull its index down. Israel has quality in its air force, intelligence and missile defence but lacks depth. Germany has the economy and industry but lacks people.
4. **Ukraine (≈ 47) is stronger than score-based ratings suggest** thanks to ground forces with combat experience, C4ISR and mass drone production. Its weak points are the economy, aviation and the navy.
5. **Iran (≈ 32) has suffered heavy damage in 2025–2026.** Its air force, air defence and economy under blockade are the “weakest link” that, under CES, determines the outcome. The preserved missile arsenal and the Strait of Hormuz provide asymmetric capabilities.

> **Assessment status.** pillar scores — an expert rapid assessment from open data as of October 2026, with an error of ±5–14 points depending on data quality. The full assessment in the programme is built from 253 indicators. The document shows how the methodology works on real countries and is not a forecast of the outcome of wars.

1. How the assessment was obtained

The assessment follows the methodology of document 1 in a simplified mode: instead of 253 indicators, each of the 12 pillars is assigned an expert score of 0–100 on the global scale (100 — the best world level). The scores rest on open data: SIPRI (2025 expenditure, nuclear forces as of January 2026), IISS Military Balance 2026, official budgets and laws, and the chronicle of the wars of 2025–2026. The rationale for each score is given in the country profiles.

Data class	Countries	σ, score points	Why
A	United States, France, United Kingdom, Germany	5–6	open budgets, parliamentary oversight, detailed statistics
B	Israel	8	opacity of part of the data, unconfirmed nuclear status
C	Russia, Ukraine	10–12	wartime: classification of the budget, losses and production; the sides' data contradict each other
D	Iran	14	opacity, IRGC off-budget expenditure, disputed damage assessments for 2026.

The final index is calculated as a CES aggregation with ρ = 0.5 across 11 pillars (strategic forces are placed on a separate axis). The following are also calculated: the MPI with the nuclear pillar, “autonomous power” without the alliances pillar (for coalition scenarios, so that allies are not counted twice), variants with other weights, and power projection over distance.

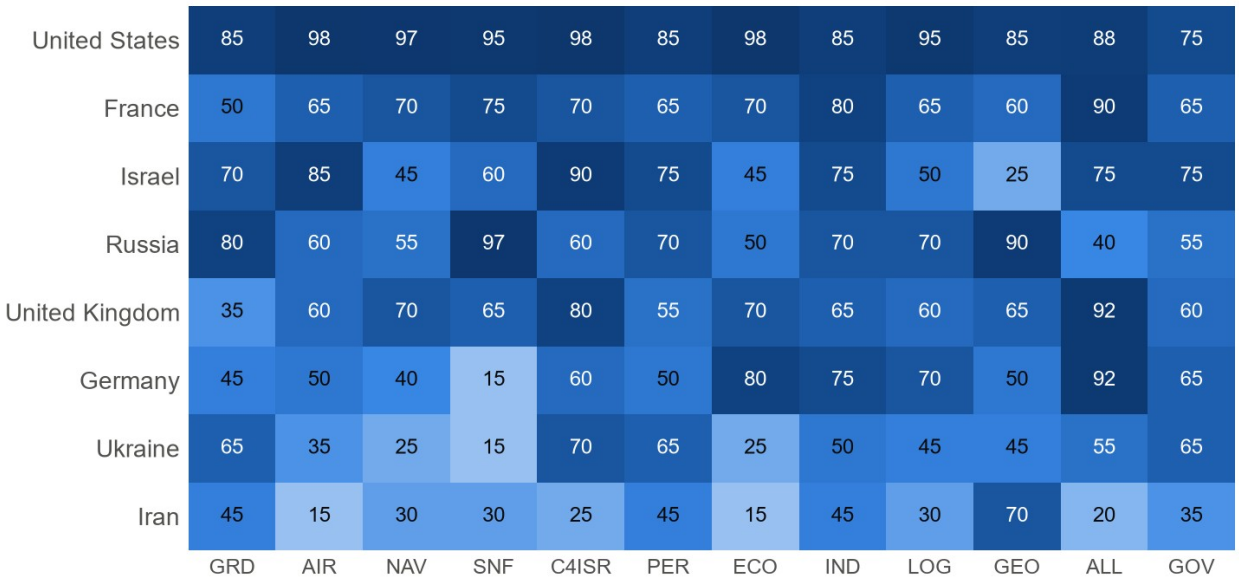


Fig. 1. Scores for the 12 pillars, 0–100. Dark colour — a strength.

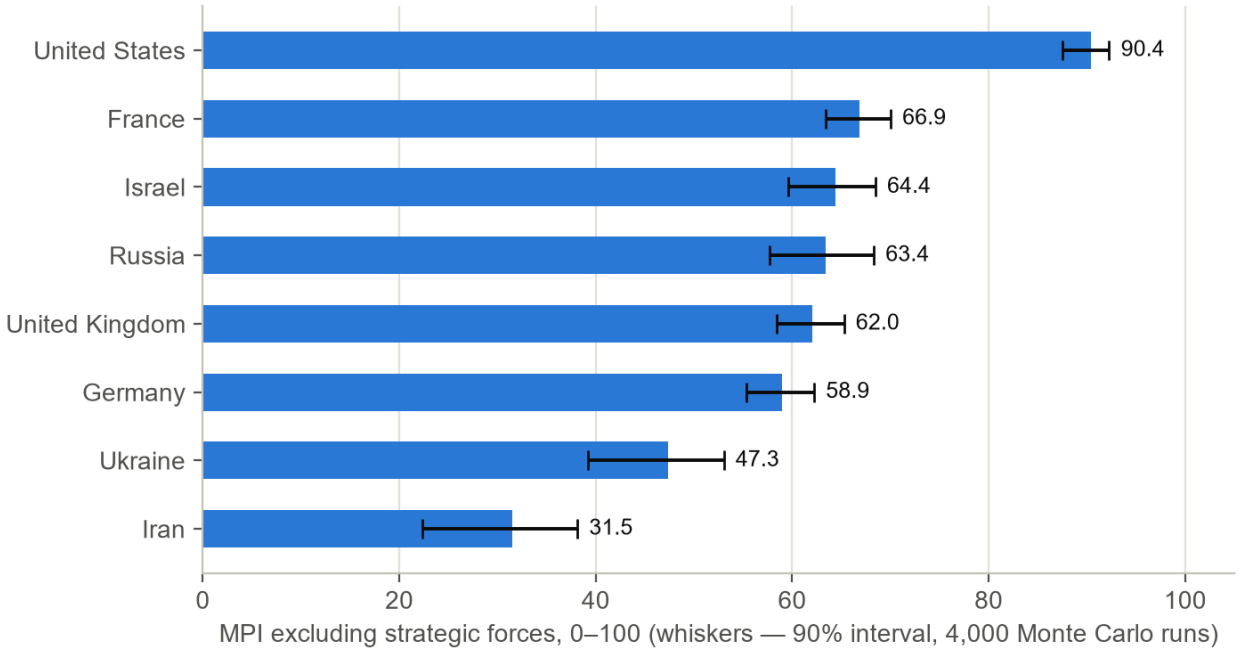


Fig. 2. MPI excluding strategic forces with a 90% uncertainty interval.

2. Comparison

2.1. Key data

Country	Military expenditure 2025, billion $	% of GDP	Rank in the world	Nuclear warheads, Jan. 2026	Service members (estimate)
United States	954	3.1	1	5,042	≈ 1.3 million
Russia	≈ 190	7.5	3	5,420	1.55 million authorised strength
Germany	114	2.3	4	— (NATO nuclear participation)	186.7 thousand
United Kingdom	89.0	2.4	6	225	≈ 140 thousand
Ukraine	≈ 84.1	40	7	—	≈ 0.9 million
France	68.0	2.0	9	370	≈ 200 thousand
Israel	48.3	7.8	11	≈ 90 (estimate)	≈ 170 thousand + 465 thousand reserve
Iran	7.4 (official)	2.1	38	—	≈ 0.6 million (pre-war estimate)

Sources: SIPRI Fact Sheet, April 2026 (expenditure, ≈ — SIPRI estimate); SIPRI Yearbook 2026 (nuclear); IISS Military Balance, national ministries (numbers, rounded).

2.2. Sensitivity to weights

The order of countries depends on the question the analyst asks. The programme makes this choice explicit through weight sets.

Country	Balanced	Conventional (≈ GFP)	Land, Europe	Protracted war	Expeditionary	ρ = 1 (sum)	ρ = −0.5 (weakest link)
United States	90.4	91.2	89.8	90.5	92.5	90.6	90.1
France	66.9	64.3	63.8	67.7	68.8	67.2	66.2
Israel	64.4	61.2	67.4	62.4	65.2	65.9	60.8
Russia	63.4	65.7	67.7	64.7	60.2	64.1	62.2
United Kingdom	62.0	58.6	56.6	61.9	65.7	62.9	60.1
Germany	58.9	55.3	56.4	62.2	58.8	59.9	57.1
Ukraine	47.3	44.9	51.1	46.6	45.0	48.8	44.3
Iran	31.5	32.0	33.7	32.5	28.1	33.2	28.2

- **Conventional weights (close to GFP):** 1. United States; 2. Russia; 3. France; 4. Israel; 5. United Kingdom; 6. Germany; 7. Ukraine; 8. Iran.
- **Land theatre in Europe:** 1. United States; 2. Russia; 3. Israel; 4. France; 5. United Kingdom; 6. Germany; 7. Ukraine; 8. Iran.
- **Protracted war:** 1. United States; 2. France; 3. Russia; 4. Israel; 5. Germany; 6. United Kingdom; 7. Ukraine; 8. Iran.
- **Expeditionary operations:** 1. United States; 2. France; 3. United Kingdom; 4. Israel; 5. Russia; 6. Germany; 7. Ukraine; 8. Iran.

Conclusion: the claim that “country X has the world's second army” without specifying the theatre, horizon and weights is incorrect. The right answer is a profile and an interval.

2.3. Power projection

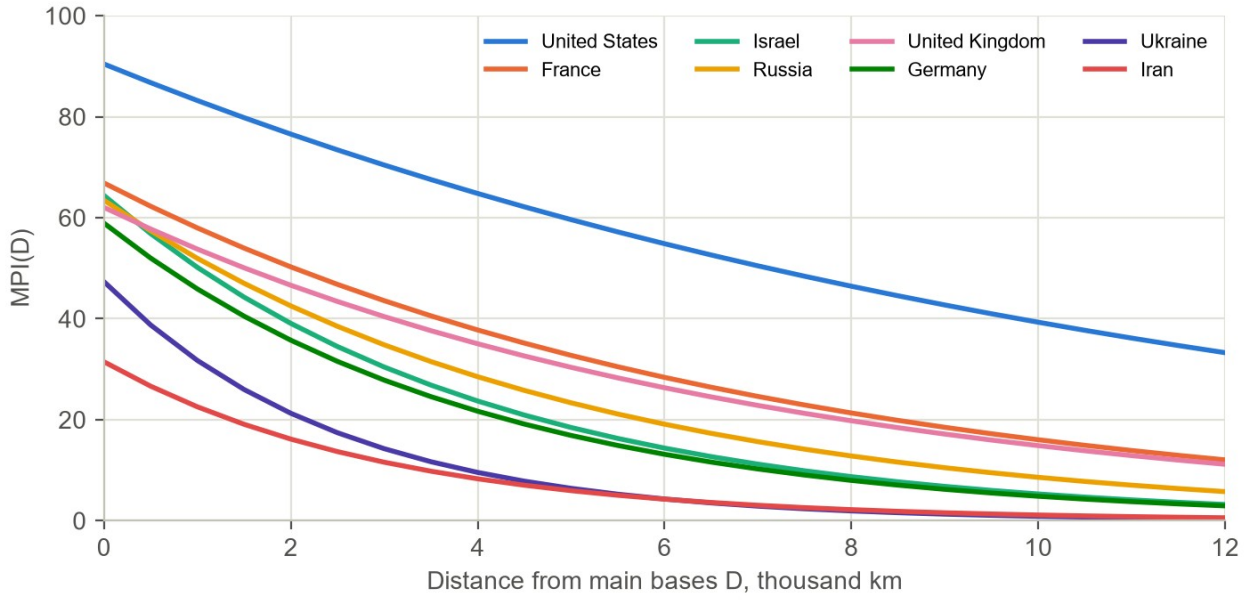


Fig. 3. MPI versus the distance of the theatre from main bases.

Country	λ, thousand km	MPI at its own borders	MPI at 2 thousand km	MPI at 8 thousand km
United States	12.0	90.4	76.5	46.4
France	7.0	66.9	50.3	21.3
Israel	4.0	64.4	39.1	8.7
Russia	5.0	63.4	42.5	12.8
United Kingdom	7.0	62.0	46.6	19.8
Germany	4.0	58.9	35.7	8.0
Ukraine	2.5	47.3	21.3	1.9
Iran	3.0	31.5	16.2	2.2

At a distance of 8 thousand km the United States retains about half of its potential, France and the United Kingdom about a third, and the rest less than a fifth. This explains why only the United States conducted operations in 2026 simultaneously in the Western Hemisphere and the Middle East.

2.4. Pairwise MPI ratios

Row ÷ column: how many times the MPI of the country in the row is higher than that of the country in the column. This is a crude measure that does not account for the theatre, coalitions or time. For specific scenarios the combat model is used (document 4).

	United States	France	Israel	Russia	United Kingdom	Germany	Ukraine	Iran
United States	—	1.35	1.40	1.43	1.46	1.53	1.91	2.87
France	0.74	—	1.04	1.05	1.08	1.14	1.41	2.13
Israel	0.71	0.96	—	1.02	1.04	1.09	1.36	2.05
Russia	0.70	0.95	0.99	—	1.02	1.08	1.34	2.02
United Kingdom	0.69	0.93	0.96	0.98	—	1.05	1.31	1.97
Germany	0.65	0.88	0.91	0.93	0.95	—	1.24	1.87

	United States	France	Israel	Russia	United Kingdom	Germany	Ukraine	Iran
Ukraine	0.52	0.71	0.73	0.75	0.76	0.80	—	1.50
Iran	0.35	0.47	0.49	0.50	0.51	0.53	0.66	—

2.5. Nuclear axis

Country	Warheads (SIPRI, Jan. 2026)	Class	Components and features
Russia	5,420	4 — triad	the largest arsenal; new delivery systems; non-strategic nuclear weapons
United States	5,042	4 — triad	modernisation of all components; Golden Dome missile defence
France	370	3 — two components	naval and air components; a declared European role
United Kingdom	225	3 — naval + NATO aircraft	Trident; purchase of the F-35A for NATO's nuclear mission
Israel	≈ 90 (estimate)	2 — limited	non-confirmation policy
Iran	—	1 — threshold (before the strikes)	enrichment facilities attacked in 2025–2026.
Germany	—	0, NATO nuclear participation	carriers for US bombs under NATO
Ukraine	—	0	renunciation of nuclear weapons in 1994.

3. United States

MPI 90.4 (90%: 87.5–92.3), rank 1 of 8 (in 90% of runs — 1). With the nuclear pillar — 90.8, without alliances — 90.6. Nuclear status: nuclear triad. Projection radius λ ≈ 12.0 thousand km. Data class: A.

Key facts

- Military expenditure in 2025 — **954 billion $** (3.1% of GDP, 33% of the world total; SIPRI). IISS expects it to exceed 1 trillion $ in 2026, including on the Golden Dome missile defence system.
- Nuclear arsenal — **5,042** warheads, of which about 1,770 are deployed (SIPRI, January 2026). A full triad.
- About **1.3 million** service members (IISS, estimate). 11 aircraft carriers, the largest fleet of 5th-generation aircraft.
- 2026: an operation in Venezuela with the capture of N. Maduro (3 January), a campaign against Iran together with Israel (from 28 February), a naval blockade of Iran (from April, resumed from mid-July). In September an agreement was signed with Denmark and Greenland on expanding the military presence.

Pillar scores and rationale

Pillar	Score	Rationale
Ground forces	85	Large armoured and infantry forces, PGMLRS, the best logistics; but the army is below the required levels and has no experience of a land war with an equal adversary.
Air force & air defence	98	The largest air force and naval aviation, F-22 and F-35, tankers, AEW&C; air dominance over Iran in 2026.
NAV	97	11 aircraft carriers, the largest nuclear submarine fleet, about 80 cruisers and destroyers; shipbuilding is the weakness.
Strategic forces	95	Triad, 5,042 warheads, modernisation (Columbia, Sentinel, B-21); close to the top of the scale.
Space, cyber, command	98	Global satellite intelligence and communications, cyber forces, leadership in military AI.
Personnel	85	A professional army, high training standards; recruitment problems of 2022–2024 partly resolved.
Defence economy	98	The world's largest economy and military budget.
Defence industry & tech	85	The most powerful defence industry, but chokepoints in munitions and interceptor output and in shipbuilding.
Logistics & mobilisation	95	Global logistics, military airlift, sea transport, energy self-sufficiency.
Geography & demography	85	Protection by two oceans, vast strategic depth; distance from theatres is offset by bases.
Alliances & presence	88	NATO, Japan, Republic of Korea, Australia, Israel; reliability reduced by the frictions of 2025–2026 (tariffs, Greenland).
Governance & experience	75	Extensive combat experience and rapid operations in 2026; political polarisation and an unpredictable policy course.

Strengths and vulnerabilities

Strengths	Vulnerabilities
Dominance in the air, at sea and in space Power projection in any theatre (λ ≈ 12 thousand km) Multipliers: intelligence, communications, AEW&C, tankers Economic and technological lead	Munitions and interceptor production lags behind the needs of a long war Shipbuilding is inferior to China Overstretched commitments: Europe, the Middle East, the Indo-Pacific region, the Western Hemisphere Declining trust of allies

Trend 2026–2030

Budget growth above 1 trillion $, a focus on missile defence (Golden Dome) and the Western Hemisphere; pressure on NATO allies to reach 5% of GDP.

4. Russia

MPI 63.4 (90%: 57.7–68.3), rank 4 of 8 (in 90% of runs — 2–6). With the nuclear pillar — 65.9, without alliances — 65.3. Nuclear status: nuclear triad. Projection radius λ ≈ 5.0 thousand km. Data class: C.

Key facts

- Military expenditure in 2025 — about **190 billion $** (7.5% of GDP, 20% of government spending, the highest in the history of SIPRI observations). The share of classified items is about 79% of the “National Defence” budget.
- Nuclear arsenal — **5,420** warheads (SIPRI, January 2026), the largest in the world. A full triad, new systems.
- Establishment strength — **1,550,500** service members (decree of September 2026). Recruitment is estimated at about 30 thousand people per month, with a decline in 2026.
- The war with Ukraine is in its fifth year. North Korean troops are involved (according to Seoul's estimate — about 15 thousand combat service members and more than 6 thousand engineers and builders since October 2024).

Pillar scores and rationale

Pillar	Score	Rationale
Ground forces	80	The largest ground force grouping in Europe with combat experience, mass artillery and drones; heavy armour losses, depletion of storage stocks.
Air force & air defence	60	Numerous aerospace forces and air defence, effective glide bombs; air dominance over Ukraine has not been achieved.
NAV	55	A strong submarine fleet; the Black Sea Fleet has suffered heavy losses from missiles and unmanned surface vessels.
Strategic forces	97	The largest arsenal, a triad, new delivery systems; the top of the scale.
Space, cyber, command	60	Strong electronic warfare, a satellite constellation; gaps in intelligence and command, dependence on imported electronics.
Personnel	70	Large numbers and combat experience; high losses, the quality of training of replacements, declining recruitment.
Defence economy	50	An economy of about 2.5 trillion $ with a high burden of 7.5% of GDP; sanctions, limited room for growth.
Defence industry & tech	70	High output of shells, strike drones and glide bombs; dependence on imported components and supplies from North Korea.
Logistics & mobilisation	70	Rail logistics, energy self-sufficiency; refineries and ports vulnerable to long-range strikes.
Geography & demography	90	Vast territory and depth, a harsh climate.
Alliances & presence	40	Belarus, North Korea (troops), partnership with Iran and China without military commitments; the CSTO is weak.
Governance & experience	55	Centralised command, war experience; inflexibility, corruption risks, personnel losses.

Strengths and vulnerabilities

Strengths	Vulnerabilities
Mass of ground forces and artillery	Casualties outpace recruitment (2026 estimates)
The largest nuclear arsenal	Economic burden of 7.5% of GDP under sanctions
War economy: high output of cheap mass means	Vulnerability of oil infrastructure to long-range strikes
Strategic depth	Weak allies

Trend 2026–2030

A course towards a war of attrition, scaling up the output of mass means; a new mobilisation is under discussion. The key question is economic resilience.

5. France

MPI 66.9 (90%: 63.4–70.0), rank 2 of 8 (in 90% of runs — 2–4). With the nuclear pillar — 67.5, without alliances — 65.4. Nuclear status: nuclear, 2-leg. Projection radius λ ≈ 7.0 thousand km. Data class: A.

Key facts

- Military expenditure in 2025 — **68.0 billion $** (2.0% of GDP; SIPRI). Under the revised military programming law — 63.3 billion € by 2027 (about 2.6% of GDP).
- Nuclear arsenal — **370** warheads in the total inventory according to SIPRI 2026 (an estimate of about 290 was cited earlier). Sea and air components.
- About **200 thousand** service members (IISS, estimate). The aircraft carrier “Charles de Gaulle”, 4 SSBNs, nuclear-powered attack submarines.
- From 2026 voluntary military service is being introduced; the reserve is planned to be brought to 50 thousand. Together with the United Kingdom it leads the “coalition of the willing” for guarantees to Ukraine.

Pillar scores and rationale

Pillar	Score	Rationale
Ground forces	50	Small but experienced expeditionary forces (Leclerc, CAESAR); limited mass for a large war.
Air force & air defence	65	Rafale, A330 MRTT tankers, SCALP cruise missiles; a limited fleet.
NAV	70	An ocean-going navy with an aircraft carrier, SSBNs and nuclear submarines.
Strategic forces	75	Independent deterrence with two components, a declared European role.
Space, cyber, command	70	Own satellites, strong intelligence.
Personnel	65	A professional army with combat experience in Africa.
Defence economy	70	An economy of about 3.3 trillion $, but a high deficit and debt constrain growth.
Defence industry & tech	80	A fully autonomous defence industry: aircraft, submarines, missiles, nuclear weapons.
Logistics & mobilisation	65	Good logistics, nuclear power generation.
Geography & demography	60	Overseas territories, global presence; distance from the eastern flank.
Alliances & presence	90	NATO, EU (Art. 42.7), strategic treaties (Greece), leadership of the coalition of the willing.
Governance & experience	65	A strong strategic culture; frequent changes of government.

Strengths and vulnerabilities

Strengths	Vulnerabilities
Fully autonomous defence industry Independent nuclear deterrence Expeditionary experience and an ocean-going navy	A small mass of ground forces Budget constraints and political instability Limited ammunition stocks

Trend 2026–2030

Accelerated budget growth, a larger reserve, an expanded role for nuclear deterrence in Europe.

6. United Kingdom

MPI 62.0 (90%: 58.4–65.3), rank 5 of 8 (in 90% of runs — 3–6). With the nuclear pillar — 62.3, without alliances — 60.2. Nuclear status: nuclear, 2-leg. Projection radius λ ≈ 7.0 thousand km. Data class: A.

Key facts

- Military expenditure in 2025 — **89.0 billion $** (2.4% of GDP; SIPRI, 6th in the world). The Defence Investment Plan (30.06.2026): about 298 billion £ over 4 years, 2.7% of GDP by 2029.
- Nuclear arsenal — **225** warheads (SIPRI), a naval component (Trident).
- About **140 thousand** service members of the regular forces (estimate); two aircraft carriers, Astute nuclear submarines.
- Political instability: in June 2026 Defence Minister J. Healey resigned.

Pillar scores and rationale

Pillar	Score	Rationale
Ground forces	35	A small army (about 70 thousand in the ground forces), a small tank fleet.
Air force & air defence	60	Typhoon, F-35B, Voyager tankers; delays in AEW&C programmes.
NAV	70	Two aircraft carriers, nuclear submarines, Type 45 destroyers; ship readiness problems.
Strategic forces	65	One naval component; purchase of the F-35A for NATO's nuclear mission.
Space, cyber, command	80	Strong signals intelligence (GCHQ), the “Five Eyes”, cyber capabilities.
Personnel	55	A professional army; a chronic shortfall.
Defence economy	70	An economy of about 3.7 trillion $; strained public finances.
Defence industry & tech	65	BAE, Rolls-Royce, MBDA UK; limited munitions capacity.
Logistics & mobilisation	60	An island position, maritime logistics.
Geography & demography	65	An island, distance from the eastern flank, global bases.
Alliances & presence	92	NATO, the “Five Eyes”, AUKUS, the Joint Expeditionary Force (JEF).
Governance & experience	60	Experienced command; political turbulence in 2026.

Strengths and vulnerabilities

Strengths	Vulnerabilities
Intelligence and allied networks Submarine fleet and deterrence High technological sophistication	Small ground force numbers Navy readiness Funding lagging behind declared tasks

Trend 2026–2030

Growth to 2.7–3% of GDP, a bet on sovereign munitions production and long-range strikes.

7. Germany

MPI 58.9 (90%: 55.3–62.2), rank 6 of 8 (in 90% of runs — 4–6). With the nuclear pillar — 54.3, without alliances — 56.9. Nuclear status: no nuclear. Projection radius λ ≈ 4.0 thousand km. Data class: A.

Key facts

- Military expenditure in 2025 — **114 billion $** (2.3% of GDP, for the first time since 1990 above 2%; 4th in the world; SIPRI). The 2026 budget — about 108 billion € (82.7 billion € core + 25.5 billion € special fund), about 152 billion € by 2029 (3.5% of GDP).
- Bundeswehr strength — **186,705** (August 2026). The target by 2035 is 460 thousand, including 200 thousand reserve.
- From 1 January 2026 a new military service law is in force (questionnaires for 18-year-olds, medical examinations for men from 2027).
- It has no nuclear weapons of its own; it participates in NATO nuclear planning. An armoured brigade is deployed in Lithuania.

Pillar scores and rationale

Pillar	Score	Rationale
Ground forces	45	Leopard 2 and a brigade in Lithuania; understrength, rebuilding after decades of cuts.
Air force & air defence	50	Eurofighter, Tornado, F-35 deliveries; strong air defence (Patriot, IRIS-T SLM, Arrow 3).
NAV	40	U212A submarines and frigates; a regional fleet.
Strategic forces	15	No nuclear weapons, NATO nuclear participation; the score reflects deterrence through an ally and long-range non-nuclear strikes.
Space, cyber, command	60	A good base, but lagging in digitalisation.
Personnel	50	Personnel shortages, ageing; a new service model from 2026.
Defence economy	80	An economy of about 5 trillion $, fiscal space after the change to the “debt brake”.
Defence industry & tech	75	Rheinmetall, KNDS, Diehl; rapid growth in munitions output.
Logistics & mobilisation	70	Europe's transport hub; dependence on energy imports.
Geography & demography	50	No common border with Russia, depth provided by allies.
Alliances & presence	92	NATO, EU; a key node of Europe's defence.
Governance & experience	65	An effective state, but slow procurement and no recent combat experience.

Strengths and vulnerabilities

Strengths	Vulnerabilities
Economic and industrial potential The fastest budget growth in Europe Air defence and a NATO logistics hub	Personnel shortages Slow procurement No combat experience

Trend 2026–2030

The largest conventional army in Europe by the 2030s if the plans are fulfilled; the key question is people.

8. Israel

MPI 64.4 (90%: 59.6–68.5), rank 3 of 8 (in 90% of runs — 2–5). With the nuclear pillar — 64.0, without alliances — 63.7. Nuclear status: nuclear, limited. Projection radius λ ≈ 4.0 thousand km. Data class: B.

Key facts

- Military expenditure in 2025 — **48.3 billion $** (7.8% of GDP; SIPRI). After the war with Iran the 2026 budget was increased to about 144 billion shekels; up to 184 billion has been requested.
- Nuclear arsenal — about **90** warheads (estimate; not officially confirmed).
- About **170 thousand** service members and about **465 thousand** reservists (IISS, estimate).
- Wars with Iran (June 2025; from 28 February 2026), a ground operation in Lebanon from March 2026, operations in Gaza and Syria. US military aid — 3.8 billion $ per year.

Pillar scores and rationale

Pillar	Score	Rationale
Ground forces	70	Experienced, well-equipped forces (Merkava, Namer) with a large reservist pool; overstretch on many fronts.
Air force & air defence	85	F-35I, F-15I/IA, F-16; air dominance over Iran in 2025 and 2026.
NAV	45	Dolphin submarines, Sa'ar 6 corvettes; a limited fleet.
Strategic forces	60	An unconfirmed arsenal of about 90 warheads, “Jericho” missiles; opacity.
Space, cyber, command	90	World-class intelligence and cyber forces, multi-layered missile defence (Iron Dome, “David's Sling”, Arrow, the Iron Beam laser).
Personnel	75	Conscripts and well-trained reservists; fatigue after three years of war.
Defence economy	45	An economy of about 0.6 trillion $; a military burden of about 8% of GDP.
Defence industry & tech	75	Advanced defence industry, record exports; dependence on US supplies of aerial bombs and interceptors.
Logistics & mobilisation	50	A small territory, dependence on seaborne imports.
Geography & demography	25	No strategic depth, surrounded on several fronts.
Alliances & presence	75	Close military ties with the US (joint operations in 2025–2026); growing international isolation.
Governance & experience	75	Vast combat experience, fast decisions; internal polarisation.

Strengths and vulnerabilities

Strengths	Vulnerabilities
Quality of the air force, intelligence and missile defence Combat experience US support	No depth or scale Expenditure of interceptors and munitions Reservist fatigue and multiple fronts

Trend 2026–2030

Record budgets, a focus on laser missile defence and long-range strikes; dependence on the United States is growing.

9. Ukraine

MPI 47.3 (90%: 39.2–53.0), rank 7 of 8 (in 90% of runs — 7). With the nuclear pillar — 44.1, without alliances — 46.8. Nuclear status: no nuclear. Projection radius λ ≈ 2.5 thousand km. Data class: C.

Key facts

- Military expenditure in 2025 — about **84.1 billion $** (40% of GDP, 7th in the world; SIPRI).
- About **0.9 million** service members (2026 estimates). No nuclear weapons of its own.
- More than 4 million drones in 2025; the plan is 7–10 million in 2026. Up to 1,000 interceptor drones per day. Long-range strikes on Russia's oil refineries and ports.
- On 11 October 2026 an “energy truce” was announced; the strikes continue. The coalition of the willing (Paris, 6 January 2026) undertook to deploy forces after a ceasefire.

Pillar scores and rationale

Pillar	Score	Rationale
Ground forces	65	A large army with combat experience, leadership in drones; a shortage of people and heavy equipment.
Air force & air defence	35	A small air force (F-16, Mirage), strong ground-based air defence but a shortage of interceptors.
NAV	25	Almost no navy, but unmanned surface vessels and missiles pushed the Black Sea Fleet back.
Strategic forces	15	No nuclear weapons; the score reflects long-range non-nuclear strikes (drones and missiles at 1,000+ km).
Space, cyber, command	70	Network-centric command, satellite communications, allied intelligence, innovation in EW.
Personnel	65	High motivation and experience; mobilisation difficulties, unauthorised abandonment of units.
Defence economy	25	An economy of about 0.2 trillion $, dependence on external financing.
Defence industry & tech	50	Mass drone production, domestic missiles; a shortage of shells and heavy equipment.
Logistics & mobilisation	45	A damaged power grid; supply through Poland and Romania.
Geography & demography	45	A large territory, but a long front and the loss of part of the territory.
Alliances & presence	55	No formal alliance; EU support, the coalition of the willing, purchases through allies.
Governance & experience	65	Rapid adaptation and decentralisation; corruption scandals, political tension.

Strengths and vulnerabilities

Strengths	Vulnerabilities
Drones and innovation Combat experience and motivation C4ISR and allied intelligence	Human resources Dependence on external financing and supplies A small air force and a shortage of air-defence interceptors

Trend 2026–2030

Ceasefire and security-guarantee talks; growth of the domestic defence industry (drones, missiles).

10. Iran

MPI 31.5 (90%: 22.4–38.1), rank 8 of 8 (in 90% of runs — 8). With the nuclear pillar — 31.3, without alliances — 32.4. Nuclear status: threshold. Projection radius λ ≈ 3.0 thousand km. Data class: D.

Key facts

- Military expenditure in 2025 according to official data — **7.4 billion $** (2.1% of GDP; SIPRI). A significant part of IRGC expenditure is not reflected.
- No nuclear weapons of its own; the nuclear programme and enrichment facilities were attacked in 2025–2026.
- About **0.6 million** service members before the war (IISS, estimate), including the IRGC.
- The 2026 war: US and Israeli strikes from 28 February, the death of Ali Khamenei, the appointment of Mojtaba Khamenei (8 March), a truce on 8 April, the resumption of fighting from 8 July, a US naval blockade. According to US intelligence (May 2026, disputed), about 70% of the pre-war missile stockpile has been preserved.

Pillar scores and rationale

Pillar	Score	Rationale
Ground forces	45	Numerous but outdated army and IRGC ground forces.
Air force & air defence	15	Old aircraft, air defence suppressed in 2025–2026; air superiority lost.
NAV	30	IRGC boats, mines and anti-ship missiles pose an asymmetric threat to the Strait of Hormuz.
Strategic forces	30	No nuclear weapons; a large medium-range missile arsenal, partly preserved in underground bases.
Space, cyber, command	25	Degradation of command after strikes on the leadership.
Personnel	45	Mass conscription, IRGC-motivated; decapitation of the command.
Defence economy	15	Sanctions, a naval blockade, falling oil exports.
Defence industry & tech	45	Own missiles and drones; according to CENTCOM, up to 90% of the defence industry has been hit (the estimate is disputed).
Logistics & mobilisation	30	Blockade, damaged infrastructure; a large territory and its own oil.
Geography & demography	70	Mountains, size, control of the Strait of Hormuz coast.
Alliances & presence	20	The “Axis of Resistance” has been weakened; Russia and China did not intervene.
Governance & experience	35	Hereditary succession, strikes on the leadership; the regime held.

Strengths and vulnerabilities

Strengths	Vulnerabilities
Missile and drone arsenal in underground bases The threat to the Strait of Hormuz Territory and depth	Air force & air defence Economy under blockade and sanctions Isolation, degradation of allies

Trend 2026–2030

A focus on missiles, maritime asymmetry and rebuilding air defence; the risk of a renewed full-scale war.

11. Limitations of the assessment

- Pillar scores are an expert assessment. A full calculation across 253 indicators will give more accurate and testable values.
- Wartime data (Russia, Ukraine, Iran, Israel) are incomplete and contradictory; therefore their σ is higher and the intervals wider.
- The index does not account for intentions, the will to fight in a particular war, or future decisions of allies.
- Snapshot — October 2026. Rapidly changing circumstances (truces, the blockade of Iran, negotiations on Ukraine) require quarterly updating.

Sources

- SIPRI Fact Sheet “Trends in World Military Expenditure, 2025”, April 2026
- SIPRI Yearbook 2026: World nuclear forces (January 2026)
- IISS Military Balance 2026 (reviews of key findings)
- Budgets and laws: the Bundestag (2026 budget, military service law), the French Ministry of Defence (LPM review, April 2026), the UK MoD (Defence Investment Plan, 30.06.2026), Israel's 2026 budget
- Britannica “2026 Iran war”; CFR Global Conflict Tracker; US intelligence estimates of Iran's missiles (CNN, NYT, WP, May 2026)
- ISW, Kyiv Independent, Moscow Times, Euromaidan Press, Militarnyi — data on the war in Ukraine, recruitment and drone production
- Al Jazeera, PBS, ABC, CBS — the “energy truce” of 11.10.2026; Gulf News — the blockade of Iran